

Corruption And Security Challenges In Nigeria: Insights From Esiaba Irobi's *Hangmen Also Die*

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Abstract

In recent years, Nigeria has been plagued by security challenges exemplified by militancy, banditry, kidnapping, assassinations, and so on, which are exacerbated by corruption. Using Irobi's Hangmen Also Die as a critical lens of analysis, this paper examines the intricate relationship between corruption and security challenges in Nigeria. The play unarguably explores the themes of corruption, social justice and security challenges. Through a critical analysis of the play therefore, this research work argues that corruption is a major factor that fuels militancy and such other security challenges, thereby giving rise to criminal networks across the country. The play is therefore a true reflection of the stark realities of Nigeria's parlous security situation while at the same time highlighting the urgent need for drastic and far-reaching reforms in the country's security architecture. By so doing, it is hoped that the root causes of insecurity such as poverty and exploitation of the poor by the rich and privileged class as well as the importance of promoting transparency and accountability among members of the leadership class will be addressed. Case study and content analysis approaches of the qualitative research method were adopted by the researcher for data collection and analysis. The primary source of data is Hangmen Also Die while the secondary sources are books, journals, magazines and newspapers from the library and the internet. The Marxist philosophy of a classless society provides the theoretical framework for the thematic and ideological position of the playwright whose work has been used in this study. Marxism contends that the masses who are the exploited class are locked in perpetual conflict with the bourgeoisie because of the tendency of the exploiter class to continue to exploit them since they (the bourgeoisie) own and control the means of production. The work recommends responsible and transparent leadership as a panacea to security challenges as captured in Hangmen Also Die. Finally, the work presents drama and theatre as tools for conscientization, reformation, transformation and national development.

Key Words: Militancy, Corruption, Social Justice, Poverty, Exploitation

Introduction

Nigeria's escalating security challenges can be attributed to the entrenched systemic disparities and exploitative governance, which have precipitated widespread disillusionment and violent resistance among the citizenry. Through the lens of Esiaba Irobi's *Hangmen Also Die*, this analysis posits that the profligacy and corruption of Nigeria's leadership class are pivotal in exacerbating these security issues. By dramatising the struggles of the oppressed and the violent repercussions of systemic injustice, Irobi's work underscores the urgent need for accountability and structural reform. This study seeks to explore how contemporary Nigerian playwrights like Irobi, utilise theatre as a platform for critiquing power dynamics and advocating for social change, thereby providing a critical examination of the complex interplay between governance, exploitation and resistance in Nigeria.

In his commentary on the state of insecurity, Festus Iyayi notes in his book entitled *Violence* that we have a prevalence of crime and violence in our society because our leaders confiscate and deny their citizens the opportunities to actualize themselves and realize their goals in life. He states that "... acts of violence are committed when a man is denied the opportunity of being educated, of getting a job, of feeding himself and his family properly..." (185). In the same vein, LaPalombara states that "all around us today, we find evidence that political systems and the governments, from cities to nations, fail to keep violence within decent bounds. In fact, these governments often instigate and perpetuate violence..." (5)

The play, *Hangmen Also Die*, illustrates how the marginalised and oppressed, fueled by desperation and frustration, resort to extreme measures such as militancy and violence to challenge the existing power structures. The Suicide Squad's actions, including the abduction and murder of Chief Erokosima, serve as a dramatic representation of this theme. According to Yekini, one of the characters in the play:

... Sometime ago, the Federal Government gave the citizens of this State... the sum of three million naira as compensation money for the oil spillage which has ruined their farms, their homes and their lives... Chief Erekosima, a commissioner for Local Government, Rural Development and Chieftaincy Affairs, connived with his councilors and local government chairmen to confiscate the 3 million naira ... No single citizen, no matter how wretched, got a single kobo. (13)

Murdering Chief Erekosima sends a clear signal from the Squad that corrupt and insensitive political leaderships whose stock-in-trade is to deny the masses their God-given opportunities to actualize themselves, will not be tolerated. Thus the Squad can be correctly said to have embarked on a cleansing mission to rid the society of rotten eggs personified by the likes of Chief Erekosima.

This study aims to investigate the intersection of corruption and security challenges in Nigeria, with a focus on how corruption contributes to instability and violence. Through a critical analysis of Esiaba Irobi's *Hangmen Also Die*, this research seeks to explore the role of theatre in representing and critiquing corruption and its impact on security. By examining the intersection of these issues, the study aims to identify potential solutions to corruption and enhance security in Nigeria. The research will be guided by several key questions, including how does corruption contribute to security challenges in Nigeria? What are the impacts of corruption on the security landscape? How does *Hangmen Also Die* represent the intersection of corruption and security challenges and what solutions can be proposed to address these issues?

The research will contribute to knowledge in several ways. Firstly, it will adopt an interdisciplinary approach, combining insights from theatre studies, political science and sociology to provide a nuanced understanding of the complex issues at play. Secondly, it will provide a contextual understanding of security challenges in Nigeria and the role of corruption in exacerbating these challenges. Thirdly, it will demonstrate the value of theatre as a tool for social commentary and critique, highlighting its potential to raise awareness and promote change. Finally, it will provide policy-relevant insights and recommendations for addressing corruption and enhancing security in Nigeria.

By exploring the intersection of corruption and security challenges through the lens of theatre studies, this research aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the complex issues facing Nigeria and to identify potential solutions to address these challenges. Ultimately, the study seeks to inform policy and practice, and to contribute to the development of more effective strategies for promoting security and stability in Nigeria.

Theoretical Framework: Marxist Approach to Social Change and Revolution in *Hangmen Also Die*

This study is grounded in the Marxist theory of social change and revolution, which emphasises the role of class struggle and revolutionary practice in transforming the society. According to Marxist ideology, social change is driven by the conflict between the exploiting and the exploited classes, with the latter seeking to overthrow the former to create a more just and equal society. The Marxist approach to revolution as reflected in the concept of scientific socialism, insists on the need for revolutionary unity among the working class, transcending divisions of religion, nationality and race. This unity is essential for challenging the dominant ideology of the ruling class and creating a new, socialist society.

Esiaba Irobi's *Hangmen Also Die* reflects this Marxist ideology, with its thematic and ideological standpoint rooted in the class struggle between the oppressors and the oppressed. The play critiques the exploitative and corrupt systems, highlighting the importance of class struggle, the need for revolutionary unity and collective action in challenging exploitative systems to achieve and promote social justice and equality.

Change Through Revolution

According to the Institute of Social Sciences, there are "... methods of a socialist transformation of human society" (18). There are radical approaches characterized by revolution, to change. Marxism is a major theory that supports the radical approach to change. Broadly speaking, socialism which may be regarded as Marxism-Leninism changed the philosophical outlook of social change, especially Marx's theory of scientific socialism. This theory "... is inseparably linked with revolutionary practice" (Institute of Social sciences, 19). What gives rise to revolution as an approach to social change is the insistence of the exploiter class to continue the exploitation of the less privileged. Therefore, Marxism insists that social change through revolution requires "Revolutionary unity of all working class people irrespective of their religion, nationality and race, the formation of the local working class as an embodiment of the revolutionary will ..." (Institute of Social Sciences, 335).

The thematic and ideological standpoint expressed by Irobi in *Hangmen Also Die*, derive from the Marxist approach to revolution. The Marxist ideology about class struggle is the philosophical premise upon which the theme of the

play rests. Marxism is a theory about political and economic changes in the society as a result of the opposition between the two dominant social classes. The conflict theory as developed by Marx examines the relationship in terms of basic inequalities between the privileged and the less privileged, otherwise, the bourgeoisie and the proletariats. The bourgeoisie also referred to as the capitalists are in a position to dominate and exploit the masses since they control the means to produce wealth. This explains why there is on-going struggle or conflict between the two classes. It is this class struggle that is fundamentally responsible for the prevalence of revolution, rebellion and other forms of security challenges, including kidnapping and banditry which the Nigerian State has continued to experience. Henslin, quoting Robert Merton, explains that the feeling of discontent created by the exploitation of the oppressed and the marginalized masses by the wealthy, privileged class elicits different responses from the masses, one of which is rebellion. This response means that the masses that are short-changed and confronted with limited opportunities and possibilities "reject both goals and legitimate means of achieving such goals". Lauer and Lauer state that rebellion is "... not only rejection of both goals and means but also a commitment to replace them with a different system..." (19) This brings us to Robert Merton's Strain Theory also captured by Lauer and Lauer thus:

People who experience strain are likely to feel anomie, a sense of normlessness. Because the dominant norms (work, education, etc) do not seem to be getting them anywhere, they have a difficult time identifying with them. They may even feel wronged by the system... Strain theory underscores the main sociological point about deviance, namely, that deviants... are not pathogenic individuals but the product of society itself... if a society emphasizes the goal of material success, groups deprived of access to this goal will be involved in... crime (203)

This is the reason that young males form or join gangs like the Suicide Squad in *Hangmen Also Die*. As a footnote to this researcher's reference to the reason for the formation of gangs, Saint Gbilekaa states that "... Furthermore, the enormous wealth as a result of the oil boom dichotomized and intensified class struggle in Nigeria as the gap between the economically privileged and the groveling proletarian and peasant class yawed abominably... (73). He states further that "violence is initiated by those who oppress, who exploit, who fail to recognize others as persons- not by those who are oppressed, exploited and unrecognized..." (92) In his opinion, Chinua Achebe states that:

Economic deprivation and corruption produce and exacerbate financial and social inequities in a population which in turn fuel political instability. Within this environment, extremists of all kinds- particularly religious zealots and other political mischief-makers find a foothold to recruit supporters and sympathizers to help them launch terrorist attacks and wreak havoc on the lives of ordinary citizens (250)

The International Encyclopedia of Sociology, Volume two, states that terrorism which can be regarded as an extreme form of violence is "... a political tactic intended to produce intimidation through the use or threatened use of violence. It has become an increasingly common feature of political disputes at both the domestic and international levels". (1408). In his conclusion, Iyayi states that violence and revolution will continue to rock the Nigerian State so long as "... whereas one man has more than enough to feed himself, his dogs, cats, children and monkeys and many other men are weak and thin from hunger and their children are suffering from kwashiorkor... (186)

Portrayal of Corruption and Security Challenges in *Hangmen Also Die*

Hangmen Also Die serves as a poignant allegory for the Niger Delta's struggles, highlighting the devastating impact of oil exploration on the region's inhabitants. The people of the Niger Delta endure unbearable living conditions, trapped in abject poverty, facing immense hardships, environmental degradation, health crises and despair, with limited access to basic necessities, all exacerbated by the activities of oil companies. This situation has led to increased militancy, kidnappings and violence, including attacks on expatriate oil workers. These actions though extreme, are often a cry for help, aimed at compelling the government to acknowledge and address the region's plight. The environmental degradation and human rights abuses in the Niger Delta sparked the activism of Ken Saro Wiwa and others, who bravely spoke out against the injustices. Their activism was met with brutal suppression, as Saro Wiwa and eight of his fellow activists were unjustly hanged by the military regime of General Sani Abacha.

The Suicide Squad emerged as a militant group in response to the long standing injustices faced by the region, with the group aiming to challenge and rectify these wrongs through violent means. The region's plight is compounded by the self-serving nature of its leadership, who prioritise personal gain over the

needs and well-being of the people they are supposed to serve. The Squad is informed by Tamara, a mother to a member of the Squad that:

... But there is a man in my local government area, a Commissioner for that matter, Chief Erekosima by name, who is being crowned the Ametemeso 1 of Izon State today. This man is a distinguished thief. He confiscated our money. Stole our 3 million naira... 3 million naira compensation money which the Federal Government gave to the citizens of Izon State, to balm our minds against the crude oil spillage which has ravaged our farms and wrecked our lives. This man seized it and is using it to crown himself today. (58)

Consequently, the Squad acting on this information, storms the venue of the ceremony, disrupts the coronation ceremony, abducts Chief Erekosima to their hideout in a bush clearing, tortures him and finally executes him. By so doing, the Squad sends out a clear signal to the audience that corruption will not be tolerated and that anybody, no matter how highly placed, who feeds on the people's sweat will be made to pay the supreme prize. Their actions and utterances also indicate that they are totally for a just society where no citizen of the State is short-changed under whatever guise. To them terrorism is the available tool to achieve this clear-cut objective. ACID, a member of the Squad justifies their actions and states that:

...Terrorism is a legitimate tactic of all down-trodden people seeking to combat oppressive governments... that revolutions are always based on terrorism. Revolutions are never achieved by holding hands and singing "we shall overcome". Revolutions are never achieved that way because a revolution is not a dinner party, it is not a disco competition, it is not an ideological romance. It is an act of insurrection where one party overthrows the other. it occurs as the accumulated grievances of the common man. It explodes like gun powder (25)

The playwright goes ahead to assert that hunger, starvation and frustration resulting from denied opportunities which the masses suffer from the leadership class are the causes of the various security challenges plaguing the country. Again ACID states that:

... Revolutions do not start in the head. They start in the stomach with starvation and hunger... with joblessness... Revolutions

topple... they frown because what they are facing is the slime, the rot, the maggots, the viruses, the nauseating residue of a consumptive society! (26)

In a barely disguised endorsement of violence as a tool which the down-trodden can use to confront their oppressors, the playwright indicates that when terrorists succeed, they are celebrated. ACID states that "the world is willing to forget and forgive the crimes of terrorism and in fact honour those it once called criminals provided the terrorist has sheathed his knife and washed blood off his hands... if a terrorist succeeds, he becomes a hero..." (26) This explains why The Niger-Delta Militants, later christened Freedom Fighters led by the likes of Asari Dokubo, Boyloaf and Tompolo were granted amnesty by the YarAdua administration. The highpoint of the amnesty programme is that they were later sent abroad for various trainings in skill acquisition as part of the Federal Government's strategy to reintegrate them into the society. But the fact is that they succeeded in drawing the attention of the Federal Government to the plight of the region. With terrorism comes vandalism of public facilities which result in economic sabotage in order to bring the Government to its knees. In those difficult days of the activities of the Niger Delta Freedom Fighters, oil installations were the main and direct targets for destruction. The idea was that the Federal Government could not continue to ignore the region that lays the golden eggs on which Nigeria's economic survival and stability rest.

The play also reveals that sometimes, young men get recruited by "respectable" members of the society to unleash mayhem on the society, most times, to hit back at their imagined or real enemies. Sometimes too, it could be to address some social ills like electoral fraud as is the case of Dr. Ogbansiegbe in the play who was rigged out of the gubernatorial elections in Imo State. In real life situations, we hear or read stories of how politicians recruit thugs to murder their opponents. RIP and Dayan, two characters in the play reveal this fact when their statements that:

... Dr. Ahitophel Ogbansiegbe was bent on hitting back on his political adversaries. And he wanted to use us as his henchmen... He succeeded for some time. Like the night he incited us to steal the car of one of the government officials. That night we stole the car and parked it in the bush... He kept using us until one night he detailed us to go and burn down the house of the chairman of

the party that rigged him out of the election. (28)

Politics in Nigeria from the first Republic to the present day is synonymous with arson, thugery, riots, electoral fraud, political assassinations, kidnapping, banditry, armed robbery and even hostage taking. In 1966, the Western region of Nigeria earned for itself, the sobriquet, "wild, wild West". The riots, killings, destruction of property in the West and in other parts of the country allegedly sponsored by corrupt politicians were mainly the factors that drew the anger of the soldiers that ended the life of the first Republic. When in 1983, the Buhari-Idiagbon coup shoved the civilian administration of Alhaji Shagari aside, the same reasons of corruption and the dangers posed to lives and property as a result of the shameful activities and conducts of politicians were adduced as reasons for the overthrow of Shagari. At the end several Executive Governors: Sam Mbakwe of old Imo State, Jim Nwobodo of old Anambra State, Lateef Jakande of Lagos State, Aper Aku of Benue State, Professor Ambrose Ali of Bendel State, Alhaji Shagari and his Vice, Dr. Alex Ekwueme, and so many others, were either sentenced to long terms of imprisonment or simply detained.

Apart from being corrupt, Chief Erekosima being a representational image of the average Nigerian politician is accused of favoritism. According to Yekini:

And the Commissioner they killed is Superintendent Daminagbo's god father. He smuggled Daminagbo into the Prison Service after Daminagbo failed the West African School Certificate in 1962. He also gave him N200,000 out of his own one million naira ... that Commissioner who they killed was also responsible for Daminagbo's rapid promotion in the Prison Service... (13)

The playwright reveals that the determination to take revenge on the society that has woefully failed the masses is the main reason that individuals resort to revolutions, banditry, kidnapping and pose huge security challenges to the society. Dimeari, one of the characters and a member of the Squad explains that he desires to be a member of the Squad because:

I want to have my own revenge on the society for what it has done to me... I have no job... no money. Which means I cannot marry... and cannot have children... I am a reject of the society. A piece of human furniture standing unobserved in the living room

of a blind world. I feel empty. I feel impotent. I feel useless. I want to do something that will shock the world. Something that will make the world realize that I exist... something violent. (51)

The failure of our leaders to meet the rising expectations of the people as a result of corrupt undoubtedly breeds security challenges. The members of the Squad attempt to defend the use of violence as a tool of confrontation with the authorities. They state that:

... So if today, we have turned to violence as the only weapon to redeem our destiny, redeem our fate, our future and our manhood, it is because... we have no place in the politics of this nation... we have no place in history... no solid earth beneath our feet... (32)

The revealing statement from the Squad explains the springing up of all kinds of militant groups in present day Nigeria. For some years now, the *Boko Haram* sect has been holding the country hostage. It has unleashed mayhem on the country, killing and maiming innocent and defenseless Nigerians; soldiers and other security personnel have been killed by the sect in their thousands, yet the situation is not getting any better. Before *Boko Haram*, we had the Niger Delta Militants who have sheathed their swords to enable relative peace and security of lives and property return to the region. Recently in the Northwestern region of the country, very close to the Nigerian border, reports have it that there is a new terrorist group known as *Lakurawa*. The group is reportedly made up of jihadists from Mali, Burkina Faso and Chad. Most of these groups posing security challenges to the country emerged as the masses' reaction to insensitive and corrupt leaderships in the country. This researcher is also of the opinion that these groups have not been defeated by the country's security forces because our leaders pay lip-service to the fight against insurgency in spite of huge budgetary provisions to enable the country's Armed Forces prosecute the war against the insurgents. Commenting on the hydra-headed monster called corruption, Chinua Achebe states that:

It would be impossible and even if possible, of little value to attempt a comprehensive picture of the type and scope of Nigerian corruption. I will only say that most people will agree that corruption has grown enormously in variety, magnitude and brazenness since the beginning of the Second Republic because it has been extravagantly fuelled by budgetary abuse

and political patronage on an unprecedented scale. Public funds are now routinely doled out to political allies and personal friends in the guise of contracts to execute public works of one kind or another, or licenses to import restricted commodities... (42)

Talking of budgetary abuse, our Senate has been embroiled in one scandal or the other bordering on "budget padding" which literarily translates to inflating the figures of the budget just to enable a few unscrupulous individuals corruptly enrich themselves from the sweat of the tax payer.

The hangman, Yekini, refuses to be persuaded to by the Prison's Doctor to hang members of the Suicide Squad. He goes on to express dissatisfaction with the Nigerian public service system, comparing his job as a Prison's Warden with his days of fulfillment as a fisherman. He states that:

... Doc, I was happy. A very happy man. A contented man... But one day, one Saturday, I remember very well, in 1965, the Superintendent, that Peketubo Daminagbo, that obtuse being shaped like a water pot came to my stilt hut at Forcados and said to me, "Yekini, my brother-in-law, I don find job for you. Better job. Warden's job... And you will be paid a salary every month..." I dropped my paddle and my net and followed him like fish follows a flattened worm... since that day, that I climbed into these uniforms and put on this black glove on my right hand and started to turn the handle of that useless hanging machine, something in me has been dying... (9)

Yekini also laments the Government's lack of interest in the welfare of its citizens as well as its failure to provide basic social amenities for members of its work force and the entire citizens of the country. He queries thus:

Why hasn't the government protected me from poverty all these years? Why has it not promoted me from Hangman to Chief Warden? Where I live, I have no water. I have no light. The stream is two miles away. I have no car. (16)

The statement above by Yekini is a sad commentary on the failure or the inability of the Nigerian Government to protect its citizens against poverty and

suffering over the years. Civil servants get stagnated and are denied their promotions for years. When they eventually get promoted, their promotion arrears are withheld and sometimes, do not get paid at all. The play also highlights that social amenities like good roads, pipe borne water are virtually non-existent in some parts of the country. Electricity supply is at best epileptic even years after the privatization of the sector. These are indications that the leadership has failed woefully, yet the same leadership class lives in mind-boggling opulence. In Abuja, our legislators claim all manner of allowances including furniture and curtain allowances. Yet, they deny civil servants, including University lecturers their dues. This can be classified as injustice because Plato in his four cardinal virtues makes it clear that there is justice if leaders give unto every citizen his due. But because the masses are denied their dues in a country like Nigeria that flows with milk, honey and crude oil, there is bound to be one form of security challenge or the other as consequences of exploitation of the masse or the people who get cheated by the system and feel so. Yekini's way of letting the authorities know that he is not happy with the system is to defy government's orders to carry out the death sentence passed on members of the Suicide Squad, hoping that by so doing, he would have contributed his quota towards changing the system for the good of the masses. He asks the doctor who has been trying to persuade him to carry out the sentence "Can your useless government protect me from the faces of the dead, the death masks I see every second in my sleep, my dream, by day light and moon light? Can the government erase the scar their grin leaves on my soul?" (17)

The militant activities of the Suicide Squad and Yekini's refusal to carry out the execution of members of the Squad, thus defying the authorities and his open condemnation of the government for its failure to adequately provide for its citizens is a reflection of the determination of the oppressed to usher in change, using tools of defiance, rebellion, revolution and banditry. This is what the playwright has striven to artistically convey to the audience.

Conclusion and Recommendations

The play reveals the self-serving nature of the leadership class who prioritises personal interest over the well-being of the people. The consequence is the continued exploitation of the citizenry and denying them access to their God-given opportunities to better their individual and collective destinies. The playwright has also shown that leaders in Africa have failed to make the

necessary provisions that will enable them to meet the rising needs of the people. Oil or mineral deposits are ordinarily nature's blessings to enable Nigerians have a meaningful existence. But these mineral deposits have become sources of misery and woes for the masses as their environment is devastated from oil spillage and the attendant pollution from the spillage. The consequences of this devastation include poverty of the worst order with attendant health challenges such as blindness, which is a serious form of disability as is the case of Ibiaye in the play and hopelessness as the people are not sure of where their next meal will come from especially since their means of livelihood which is fishing have been destroyed by oil spillage. That is the absurdity of our existence in Africa's most endowed country.

The researcher has therefore, been able to deduce from the analysis of the play that the contention of the playwright is the fate of the average Nigerian in a materialistic, capitalist, corrupt, exploitative and selfish society where there is serious imbalance between leaders and the less privileged. One of the expressions of this observation for instance, is lack of faith in the ability of the Nigerian government to put measures in place to ensure that the people enjoy the basics of social amenities. This research work also reveals, although with dismay, how easily and without conscience, our politicians hijack and divert the government's interventions meant to assuage the sufferings of the masses. This play can therefore be rightly referred to as an artistic instigation of doubts on the ability of leaders in Nigeria to make the country a model of good governance in Africa. Through content analysis of the play, the researcher is able to reveal that part of the reasons that Nigeria is referred to as the poverty capital of the world with stunted economic growth and development is traceable to the hypocritical attitude exemplified by the insensitivity of the country's leaders to the plight of the less privileged.

The researcher therefore, recommends that Nigerian playwrights should continue to use their art to encourage the government to rise up to its responsibility of providing basic amenities, employment opportunities as well as ensure that the masses are not unduly exploited and short-changed. It also recommends that the radical theatre genre should be explored as the Nigerian masses who are predominantly down-trodden have a lot to benefit from it, especially as drama has come to be a veritable tool for liberation, reformation, transformation and change that it represents to ensure a better society. That way the image of the theatre as a seriously inclined medium of change rather

than an entertainment medium would have been enhanced.

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